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### Mindset: Are You Growing or Stagnant?

Life is filled with choices. Each choice is born out of a thinking philosophy or determination to master a hidden agenda. What everyone must ask themselves is how do they approach life? Are they filled with purpose and resolution to become all that they can be? What people tend to not understand is that it all comes down to the way choices are viewed. The decision to push past the easy, simple, and uncomplicated outlook on life to ferret out potential. Only once that has been accomplished will a new perspective take root, and life can be approached with purpose.

In her essay “From Mindset: Psychology of Success,” author Carol Dweck explains that life can be approached with two different mindsets. Dweck also argues that the mindset that is used will contribute to the effectiveness each person will have in life. The first mindset is the fixed mindset in which one believes that “your qualities are carved in stone...creat[ing] an urgency to prove yourself over and over” (1607). The second mindset is the growth mindset which is “based on the belief that your basic qualities are things you can cultivate through your efforts” (1612). Throughout her essay, Dweck compares the two mindsets, offers examples of each one, and provides opportunities for the readers to self-diagnose themselves on which mindset they currently have. She encourages a growth mindset as it is the mindset that will provide individuals with the opportunity to thrive during difficult and challenging times (1612). Dweck uses ethos and pathos effectively to convince her audience that they need to have a

growth mindset; however, her overtly strong logos is what ties her argument together, making it effective and relatable.

Dweck's use of ethos provides an image portraying herself as a scholar intent on solving life's mysteries. She begins her essay with "when I was a young researcher, just starting out, something happened that changed my life" (1603). By beginning her paper this way, Dweck is stating that she has a personal stake and interest in her topic. Her passion further comes through when she wrote "I was obsessed with understanding how people cope with failures, and I decided to study it" (1603). She goes on to describe an experiment she personally conducted which served to motivate her to understand the results. By personally having a stake in the results and observing the experiment herself, she is proving to her audience that she is invested in her research and an expert in her field. Dweck also quotes Binet, the creator of the IQ test, and Robert Sternberg, an intelligence guru, to lend credibility to her position.

Paired with her use of ethos, Dweck employs pathos to emotionally contribute to her argument. The use of conversational first-person point of view throughout the essay provides the tone that this topic is personal to the author. First person point of view also serves to engage more personally with the audience with a focused viewpoint. By stating "I've seen so many people with this one consuming goal of proving themselves – in the classroom, in their careers, and in their relationships" Dweck provides relatable examples for her readers to correlate with (1610).

Additional pathos is added to her writing when Dweck attempts to address the question, "do people...believe that anyone can be anything, that anyone with proper motivation or education can become Einstein or Beethoven?" (1612). Her follow up to this question was to ask another question "did you know that Darwin and Tolstoy were considered ordinary children?"

(1612). This furthers her emotional appeal that the readers of the essay do not have to be “special” to thrive during challenges. By pointing out that well-known people such as Darwin or Tolstoy were ordinary, Dweck is creating the connection that everyday people can be effective in the world today. This connection carries heavy emotions for readers as everyone desires to “take the risks, confront the challenges, and keep working on them” (1616).

Humor is also used to create an emotional appeal to the audience. Dweck presents a relatable comic that represents how one evaluates situations with the questions “Will I succeed or fail? Will I look smart or dumb? Will I be accepted or rejected? Will I feel like a winner or a loser?” (1610). Each of these questions are based on emotion and therefore will have emotional answers. The comic, while funny, preys on emotion because each reader will interpret the comic differently. Yes, the characters of the comic are drawn to attract laughter, but the dialogue taking place between the characters is focused on invoking emotions in the reader to promote reflection.

Dweck balances her claims with logos to expand on her argument and tie all her main points together. She logically encourages her audience to decide for themselves which mindset they have. Towards the end of her essay she engages with the readers by asking the question “which mindset do you have?” (1618). After asking that question, she follows up with additional logical, easy to understand questions that the readers can use to self-diagnose themselves. By approaching her audience this way, she is putting the responsibility into the readers’ hands to recognize what their abilities and personal qualities show about their mindset. Questions evoke self-reflection and challenge what is known about oneself. Dweck applies this logic when she writes “if [you], like those with the growth mindset, you believe you can develop yourself, then you’re open to accurate information about your current abilities” (1618). She then uses the

questions to serve as guidance for directing her audience to deciding which mindset they are more prone to reside in.

Another way Dweck employs logos is with a visual flowchart at the end of her essay. The flowchart summarizes her entire essay into a logical, easy to follow, visual example. It serves to compare how the two mindsets process challenges, obstacles, exports, criticisms, success of others, and what the ending result of each mindset is (1623). Ending her essay with a chart is a guaranteed way to leave an impression on a reader's mind. Charts are used like a funnel; they reiterate the main points and slowly guide the readers through the essay's main points until the conclusion or call to action is reached.

Finally, Dweck's logical approach to the order of her essay presents smooth and understandable transitions between points. Her introduction begins with a personal story that employs ethos, but it also serves to provide the background information needed to understand the importance of her research. She then hooks her audience at the end of her introduction with the question "What are the consequences of thinking that your intelligence or personality is something you can develop, as opposed to something that is a fixed, deep seated trait?"(1605). Her first section of the essay ends this way to encourage the audience to desire to go on the journey with her to understand the results. Dweck then logically proposes that there are two mindsets available and provides detailed questions to guide the reader into the discovery of which mindset they currently have. Then to wrap up her essay, she employs a concise conclusion briefly summarizing her entire essay once again and encouraging her readers to adopt a growth mindset. By ordering her essay this way, the reader is easily able to connect each of the main points together and reach a logical conclusion on their own. If the essay were not ordered in this way, the author would be difficult to follow, not as relatable or engaging, and Dweck's logos

would be damaged. In this case, her logos is established based on her logical ordering throughout the essay.

Through her use of ethos, logos, and pathos, Dweck convinces her readers to become active in self-diagnosing their own mindsets. She uses ethos to establish herself as a scholar and an expert in her field of study. Her use of pathos provides a distinctive touch to her paper by engaging her audience using first person point of view. Although her use of logos is heavy throughout her essay, it is what ties her ethos and pathos together to make an effective argument. Her logical approach to the flow of her essay is apparent as she gently guides her audience through the essay towards a better understanding of the importance of mindset. Altogether, Dweck uses her rhetoric appeals effectively to make her argument to her readers. So, what is the right mindset to have? According to Dweck, having a growth mindset is where “intelligence can be developed. It leads to a desire to learn and therefore a tendency to embrace challenges and persist in the face of setbacks” (1623).

Works Cited

- Dweck, Carol. "From Mindset: The New Psychology of Success" *From Inquiry to Academic Writing: A Text and Reader*. 5<sup>th</sup> ed., edited by Stuart Green and April Lidinsky. Bedford/St. Martin's, 2021, pp. 1603-1623.